

SPI 387: Education Policy

Week 11 Precept

Assumptions Required For Efficiency Under Free Markets and Their Application to Schooling

Assumption 1

Assumption: Choices of individuals to not affect other people.

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Schooling reality: Individual schooling choices affect other people in many ways. They create external effects on the community (e.g., longer term effects on civic participation, crime, and public health) and affect neighborhood social bonds. They also involve peer effects, an example of externalities in production, that induce schools to select their preferred students.

Assumption 2

Assumption: Consumers (and producers) have good information

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Schooling reality: Families have imperfect information. Parents do not observe schooling directly. Output is complex and ambiguous and arises far in the future. We also cannot easily attribute output to schools because of contributions from families and other contextual factors (i.e., “joint production”).

Assumption 3

Assumption: Consumers (and producers) have many options to choose from.

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Schooling reality: Families have limited options. They must transport their children to and from school every day, a geographic constraint, and production is subject to economies of scale so that schools need to be large and few in number.

Assumption 4

Assumption: No switching costs exist.

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Schooling reality: Switching costs are high. School curricula, rules, and norms vary and require students to adjust. Schools also entail layers of social relationships that are broken when students switch schools.

Assumption 5

Assumption: Demand is flexible.

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Schooling reality: Schooling demand is nearly fixed. Parents have a legal and moral responsibility to care for and educate their children. They cannot easily do this while working inside and outside the home.

Assumption 6

Assumption: Technology can be improved, and those gains can be monetized through intellectual property rights.

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Schooling reality: Establishing intellectual property rights for school improvement is inherently difficult. Quality is mostly about implementation. Few important schooling products and even fewer processes can be patented or copyrighted.

“Dollars to Discriminate” by Eckes et al

- Some private, religious schools that accept vouchers have been accused of discriminating against certain populations of students through their admissions processes
- History of vouchers is laden with racism (e.g. used to maintain segregation in Southern state after Brown v Board); in present, media reports suggest that schools which accept vouchers discriminate against LGBTQ+ populations
- Authors' analysis shows that no states have laws that provide explicit protections for all marginalized populations, and most states only provide specific protections for race and ethnicity

Bases of Discrimination

- Basis of Religion
- Basis of Race
- Basis of National Origin/Ethnicity
- Basis of Disability
- Basis of Sex
- Basis of Sexual Orientation (a biggie)

Eckes et al. argue that since voucher programs are public programs that rely on public money, the schools that receive those public funds should be open to any student, and this should be explicitly encoded in the state voucher laws

Discussion Question

Think back to the Mahmoud v. Taylor court case from Week 9. Do you think there are any similarities in the logic used to justify that court decision, and the logic that may be used to justify allowing discrimination by sexual orientation? Do you think there are any notable differences?

“The Values-Based Case for School Choice Is Also the Winning Case”

- This article is authored by Lindsay Burke and Jay Greene, researchers at the Heritage Foundation, a prominent conservative think tank
- CERN web page: <https://www.aei.org/conservative-education-reform-network/>

Key Points

- In their quest for broad support for school choice, proponents have conceded to Democrats' policy demands, including limited student eligibility and heavy-handed regulations, ultimately weakening the options available to families.
- Yet, these concessions haven't won Democratic policymakers' support and may have alienated Republican policymakers.
- School choice supporters, therefore, should not be afraid to make what is likely our most compelling case: that education freedom is fundamentally about enabling parents to choose learning environments that align with their values.
- For long-term success, school choice supporters must make the values-based case for school choice, pursue programs that are open to every child, and allow parents to determine what constitutes quality and accountability.

Activity

Your group has been assigned a character. With your partners, discuss how you would frame school vouchers in a way that would make your character support their implementation. Write down any ideas you have; we will reconvene and you'll get a chance to share them.

If there's time: now, discuss how you could frame school vouchers in a way that would make your character oppose their implementation.